



Exploratory User Research

Prepare a semi-structured interview guide

Preparing a semi-structured interview guide helps ensure that data collection is systematic while still allowing flexibility to explore unexpected insights that emerge during the conversation.

[Learn more in the UX/UI Guidance section](#)

Why does it matter in this phase?

In exploratory user research, the goal is not to validate predefined assumptions, but to **understand users' experiences, needs, and perspectives in depth**. A semi-structured interview guide provides a balance between consistency and openness: it ensures that **key topics are covered** across participants, while allowing the researcher to **adapt questions based on participants' responses and context**.

0%

Step by step guidance



Define the research objectives

Clarify what you aim to learn from the interviews and how this relates to your broader research questions. Objectives should focus on understanding users' needs, motivations, behaviors, or challenges rather than evaluating solutions.



Identify key themes and topics

Determine the main topics that need to be covered during the interview (e.g. current practices, pain points, decision-making processes, contextual constraints). These themes will structure the interview guide.



Formulate open-ended questions

Write open-ended questions that encourage participants to describe experiences in their own words. Avoid leading questions or terminology that presupposes specific answers.



Define follow-up and probing questions

Prepare optional probes that can be used to deepen understanding, clarify responses, or explore emerging themes without disrupting the conversational flow.



Decide on interview structure

Organize questions in a logical sequence, typically moving from general topics to more specific ones. Include a short introduction and closing section to contextualize the interview and allow participants to add final remarks.



Pilot the interview guide

Test the guide internally or with a small number of participants to assess clarity, timing, and relevance. Use feedback to refine question wording or structure.



Document rationale and assumptions

Briefly document why specific topics and questions were included, and note any assumptions underlying the interview design. This supports transparency and later academic justification.

Documentation to produce



Don't forget to upload them in the documentation section!



Interview guide document

A structured document outlining interview sections, questions, and optional probes.



Research objectives statement

A short description linking interview questions to the overall research goals.



Pilot feedback notes

Notes documenting insights and adjustments made after testing the interview guide.

Recommended tools



Notion



Google Docs



Miro

Assignee



Naomi García

Collaborator